US-Ukraine rift will outlast resumed intel-sharing

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Diplomatic fallout with Ukraine will persist beyond intelligence-sharing resumption

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President Donald Trump is in the thrall of a long-shot peace deal between Russia and Ukraine, and while the current fracture in US-Ukraine relations is unlikely to be permanent, it will persist through the coming winter and create substantial diplomatic hurdles for Kyiv.

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The lack of US diplomatic backing for Ukraine in negotiations and limitations on offensive strike assistance would persist in our most likely scenario (60% odds), while defensive aid would resume and continue, deliveries of additional interceptors would be unlikely to restart until after the next round of Iran escalation.

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The best-case scenario for Ukraine is a repeat of the post-Alaska summit collapse in US-Russian engagement that pushed Trump toward Kyiv out of frustration with Putin (30% odds), while a worst-case scenario would see Trump blame GOP midterm losses on the failure to reach a deal, leading him to cut all assistance to pressure Ukraine into capitulation (10% odds).

It's all about the deal, or at least Trump’s expectation of one. Trump’s central preoccupation is not whether Ukrainian sovereignty is preserved or whether European allies are on board. It is whether he is the one to close the deal to end the war, preferably as soon as possible. Trump gravitates toward whichever party appears to hold the stronger hand, on the instinctive calculation that siding with strength is the shortest route to a signature. This does not always favor Russia; earlier this summer, Trump openly celebrated Ukrainian long-range strikes deep into Russian territory. The cyclical nature of US policy will likely lead Washington to pivot back to Ukraine eventually, though it will be a protracted process and leave the relationship worse off than before. Over time, this cyclical pattern trends negatively for Ukraine.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky's recent offer to accept a frozen conflict along the current lines of contact is a shrewd tactical countermove, an attempt to call the US’s bluff by offering Trump something he can plausibly sell as a win. Domestic politics matters too: a significant majority of US voters, including within Trump’s MAGA base, favor Ukraine. Congressional backlash will come to a head in mid-December, when pro-Ukraine members can threaten a government shutdown or a freeze on new military funding—essential for the war in Iran—to force Trump to change course.

Bureaucratic fractures will keep some aid alive—but not all of it. US public opinion remains heavily tilted against Russia and toward Ukraine, and no one wants to "own" the pressure campaign being waged in search of a deal. This sets a floor that likely keeps core defensive aid flowing. There will be interruptions, as already seen in the failure to deliver early strike warnings (likely in part a technical limitation) and the pause in interceptor deliveries via the Priority Utilization Requirements List (PURL) program, though both will ultimately survive. Interceptor deliveries are unlikely to resume until after the next round of US escalation in the Middle East, however.

Offensive support will likely remain curtailed, at least partially. Credit for the decision to throttle Starlink-provided targeting systems is being tossed between the White House and Elon Musk. In the end, who ordered it matters less than the reality that Ukrainian offensive support is a fragile construct that will be the first casualty in any effort to pressure Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky.

Ukraine's best case is a rapid collapse of the Washington-Moscow rapprochement. This round of US-Russian engagement is unlikely to produce a deal, but for as long as the diplomatic engagement continues, Kyiv will find itself at a disadvantage. The post-Alaska summit collapse last summer, where Trump rejected Russia's position and eventually moved to vocally supporting long-range Ukrainian strikes, offers a framework for how this might unfold.

It will be harder this time. In the year since the Alaska summit there has been increased discussion about future economic ventures between the US and Russia, and the bar for Trump to walk away in frustration is likely higher. The personal relationship between Trump and Zelensky is also at a low point, and Trump would likely demand the personal animus be papered over by some public conciliation from the Ukrainian side.

Ukraine's worst case is being blamed for GOP midterm losses after the fact. Trump has so far appeared unconcerned with potential losses in the upcoming midterms, though that may change rapidly once those losses materialize. It doesn't matter that the diesel deal with Russia will not lower US prices ahead of voting. What matters comes after, when the White House (potentially) goes looking for who to blame for losses driven in part by those high prices.

If Trump judges Russia to be the more cooperative partner at that point, Ukraine will face its worst-case outcome. All but the most essential defensive intelligence sharing would be curtailed, new weapons deliveries indefinitely paused, and Kyiv left more isolated from the US than at any point since the war began.

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